

Cultural Capital and the Literary Field

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The literary field has been conceptualized in social scientific work as patterned in particular ways. Historically, popular reading has been linked with contested processes of social change. Tastes for reading have, following Bourdieu, been seen as embedded in continuing processes of distinction and the making of hierarchies. Research has demonstrated the ways in which these hierarchies might be reflective of gender as well as of class relationships. This article examines the findings of the Cultural Capital and Social Exclusion study in the light of these debates. The survey gathered data about the types of reading material used by a representative sample of the United Kingdom (UK) population, including their preferences for newspapers, magazines and books. The article reports on a number of possible relationships identified in the study about the location of reading as a social practice, drawing on the survey data and explanatory accounts of respondents' reading preferences drawn from focus groups and interviews. The regularity of participation in reading and ownership of books are outlined in relation to occupational class. Evidence relating to the reading of magazines and newspapers is then examined in the light of contemporary policy concerns. Patterns of taste in books are explored, examining preferences for 'literary' genres, gender, education and ethnicity. The article concludes by addressing the position of taste for, and knowledge of, specific works representing a range of positions within the literary field to complete the picture of cultural capital and the literary field in the contemporary UK.

Keywords: Cultural capital; Reading; Social exclusion

Introduction

This article reports the findings from the *Cultural Capital and Social Exclusion* (CCSE) project relating to reading practices in the contemporary United Kingdom (UK). The project asked a number of questions about involvement and preferences within, and knowledge of, the contemporary literary field. These included questions about ownership of books, regularity of reading for leisure, preferences for certain genres and

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experiences of particular titles and authors. The survey also included questions about more general reading practices including involvement in, and preferences for, magazine and newspaper reading. All these questions were asked in an historical, theoretical and policy context in which reading has been conceptualized as a particular type of activity with particular kinds of resonance. Reading is connected with debates about literacy and its central place in policy concerns with education and skills development. It is also connected with 'literature' and its central and consecrated place in established hierarchies of 'good' and 'bad' culture. It is intimately linked with institutions, such as schools and universities, which are engaged in the processes of cultural consecration. The tensions between these two overlapping conceptions of reading have important consequences for policy approaches to the literary field, but this article takes the latter concern with the literary as its focus.

For Bourdieu (1984) there were identifiable, measurable homologies between preferences for and engagement in particular cultural activities, arranged into hierarchies, and positions in social and economic hierarchies. These produce a complex relationship between the kind of person one is or is likely to become and one's tastes for music, reading and the arts, amongst other things. Particular prominence is given in Bourdieu's analysis of mid-1960s' France to the different spread of reading tastes across what he terms the different fractions of the dominant class, with a taste for what we might term the literary, i.e. novels or philosophy books rather than genre fiction, being largely, but not exclusively, located within the professions (including teachers) as opposed to within commercial or industrial employers or managers. Consideration is also given to taste for newspapers and its relation to various forms of political knowledge and engagement. Those with higher levels of education are, in Bourdieu's analysis, far more likely to choose titles which might resonate with our more contemporary conceptions of 'quality' rather than regional or 'popular' newspapers, reflecting, he argues, differing levels of interest in, and connection to, social and political issues and debates. Such findings offer little surprise in the contemporary context and, to some extent, our findings re-iterate them. A more subtle probing of our data, though, can generate more revealing and interesting findings in terms of contemporary conceptions of the literary and, more broadly, contemporary conceptions of reading as a social practice. There are three particular points that help illuminate and to some extent problematize our data.

First, in a recent study of organized reading groups in the United States (US), Elizabeth Long suggests that whilst reading appears to be an individual or private practice (even a profoundly individual one, given its connections with notions of personal development or 'self' discovery), it has a public and *social* infrastructure whereby:

Groups of people and institutional processes, from standardised testing to censorship, shape reading practices by authoritatively defining what is worth reading and how to read it. This authoritative framing affects what kinds of books are published, reviewed and kept in circulation in libraries, classrooms and the marketplace, while legitimating only certain kinds of literary values and certain modes of reading. (Long, 2003, p. 11)

This points to the complex and contested ways in which reading has, and continues to be, connected to questions of educational and cultural policy. The second critical point is identified by Raymond Williams (1961) in his account of the emergence of the reading public. Williams points out that there have been two confused and contradictory conceptions of *value* shaping attitudes toward public tastes for reading:

On the one hand there is the fear that, as the circle of readers extends, standards will decline and literature will be threatened by 'blotterature'. Related to this, but involving other prejudices, has been an essentially political fear that, if the common man [sic] reads, both quality and order (sometimes the one standing for the other) will be threatened. (Williams, 1961, p. 179)

A concern with reading, then, can be conceptualized not simply as a concern with whether or not people read at all but also, if they do read, whether the types of reading they are engaged in are 'correct' or somehow wasteful or corrosive. Social and historical accounts of the history of reading in the UK and the US (Carey, 1992; Rose, 2001; Rubin, 1992; Vincent, 1981) have demonstrated the ways in which mass readership itself, rather than its lack, has been the more prevalent social and to some extent policy problem of recent centuries. This notion of dangerous reading is central to the third framing point, in relation to questions of hierarchy and value.

Contemporary accounts of hierarchy in cultural terms emphasize the apparently altered and muddled relationships between 'high' and 'low'. These accounts partly emerge from academic interest in popular cultural forms which has led to recognition, including at the level of policy, that 'high' and 'low' are contested categories and that forms of popular culture have worth. Such accounts have an empirical ally in the omnivore thesis developed by Peterson and Kern (1996) that broadly argues for the existence of new forms of cultural engagement which eschew traditional forms of snobbery. Interestingly, although notions of 'high' and 'low' in literature have been affected by changes in education and transformations in the publishing industry (Bloom, 2002; Gelder, 2004), reading has been less central to the development of the omnivore thesis than other forms of cultural participation, notably music. Studies of women's reading, by contrast, have pointed up the extent to which notions of literary hierarchy and value are persistent and implicitly gendered, with romance reading in particular exemplifying a diminished, trivial and frivolous form (Fowler, 1991; Radway, 1984). Following this model, it might also be that lower socio-economic groups or ethnic minorities with less leverage through which to engage in the consecration of their particular forms of reading activity (enabled by their inclusion in educational curricula, for example) will have such activities ignored or dismissed as trivial or frivolous.

In the light of these three points (the social infrastructure of reading, the contested idea of reading as a social good and the persistently gendered or otherwise divided nature of reading preferences), the CCSE data, both the survey and the qualitative material provided by household interviews and focus group discussions, offer a

revealing picture of the contemporary literary field and the broader 'field of reading' of which it is a part.

Part 1: The Policy Context

While there is some state support for writers, organized through the various national Arts Councils, literary production is a largely private-sector concern within an increasingly concentrated, globally organized publishing industry (Thompson, 2005), the products of which are intimately linked with other aspects of entertainment and media culture. The consumption of books is a public policy concern, though, not least through the institution of the public library, which has a particular interest in trends in reading tastes as part of its service provision. The Department for Culture, Media and Sport (DCMS)'s *Framework for the Future* document concerning library development in the contemporary UK (DCMS, 2003) contains a number of conceptualizations of the value of reading. Amongst the presumed social benefits of reading are enabling active citizenship, generating an 'informed consumerism' and stimulating the imagination. The National Literacy Trust (2005), in its document *Every Which Way We Can*, concerning the policy challenge of literacy and social inclusion, emphasizes, in a manner similar to equivalent documents produced by a variety of participatory arts programmes (Jermyn, 2001), the possibility of engagement with reading practices as a means of alleviating social exclusion for at-risk groups. These effects are particularly likely amongst children and young people, but also amongst adults from deprived areas. In both documents, the ownership of books in and of itself is seen, in a way which fits neatly with a Bourdieusian perspective on the inter-generational transmission and reproduction of cultural capital, as a key variable in the development of a culture of reading, from which assumed social benefits will flow. Both documents emphasize the importance of reading to and for children as a means of equipping them with the technical skills required for educational or economic success as well as the conceptual skills of self-reflection and personal development enabled through an engagement with the literary.¹

The CCSE survey asked a number of questions about a variety of reading activities, including questions about the ownership of books and preferred newspapers and magazines. Participation in 'book culture' was the pursuit of a significant minority. Forty-five per cent of our sample had read five or more books in the previous year, while just over 20 per cent had read none. In terms of book ownership, 55 per cent of survey respondents report owning over 50 books and only 5 per cent own none. Table 1 indicates the spread of this ownership across occupational classes, demonstrating that, at the high and lower ends, there are indications of a relationship between book ownership and socio-economic position. If we compare respondents in routine occupations with those in higher professional occupations we can see that, in the former category, 43 per cent own less than 20, compared to only 8 per cent of higher professionals. Over 50 per cent of higher professionals own more than 200 books, compared to only 9 per cent of those in routine occupations. Owning books is not the same as reading them, but there appears to be a similar relationship,

Table 1 Percentages of Occupational Classes Who Own and Had Read Books

	Occupational class ^a											
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Number owned												
0	3	0	1	3	1	2	2	10	5	8	12	29
1–10	7	1	3	13	10	9	10	8	13	11	17	17
11–20	7	7	7	5	6	5	8	8	10	13	14	15
21–50	20	14	17	25	25	25	26	21	30	20	21	15
51–100	17	12	18	18	18	22	19	21	26	20	21	7
101–200	10	15	21	15	10	19	16	14	10	15	7	7
201 +	37	52	34	23	30	19	20	19	8	14	9	10
Number read in the last year												
0	27	3	9	18	13	14	22	31	37	21	34	31
1–5	17	28	31	42	33	34	37	32	32	39	40	31
6–25	43	49	37	31	37	31	21	27	25	28	16	29
26–60	7	15	14	6	11	14	11	7	5	9	5	7
61 +	7	4	9	3	6	6	10	3	2	3	6	2
Total number	30	93	236	78	70	187	112	123	63	322	200	42

^aOccupational classes: 1 Employers large organizations/higher managerial; 2 Higher professional occupations; 3 Lower professional/higher technician; 4 Lower managerial; 5 Higher supervisory; 6 Intermediate occupations; 7 Employers small organizations & own account workers; 8 Lower supervisory; 9 Lower technician; 10 Semi-routine occupations; 11 Routine occupations; 12 Never worked.

also demonstrated in Table 1, between being in professional or other high-ranking occupations and *reading* books. Seventy-four percent of those in routine occupations had read less than five books in the previous year, whilst 68 per cent of those in the higher professional occupations had read more than five. This offers some indication that book culture is characterized by the intensive participation of the socio-economically privileged.

When reading newspapers and magazines is added to this picture, almost the entire sample, some 98 per cent, were involved in some form of reading activity. In fact, only 33 people in the sample said they engaged in no reading activities whatsoever. Newspaper reading was popular, with 76 per cent of the sample choosing a preferred daily title. Most popular were *The Sun*, chosen by 266 or 17 per cent of the sample, and *The Daily Mail*, chosen by 237, or 15 per cent. Similarly, 68 per cent of the sample was able, when prompted, to identify a favourite magazine title. The range of magazines titles reflected the size and scale of this sector of publishing. Women's magazines were the single most popular category of magazine, being chosen by 20 per cent of respondents. Magazines devoted to celebrity culture and entertainment were the second most popular category (being chosen by 8 per cent of respondents), with mechanical and technical magazines (including computer magazines) the next most popular category, chosen by 7 per cent. It is noteworthy that, in our focus group discussions, newspaper and magazine reading generated considerable critical discussion, particularly around magazines with a target identity-based audience. The focus group held in London with

professional women who were lesbians, for example, generated the following exchange about the use of magazines within the lesbian and gay community.

Moderator: You wouldn't buy *Diva*?

Chloe: On a matter of principle.

Moderator: What principle's that?

Chloe: I wouldn't go near it. Because it's crap and it insults me.

Tanya: You read *Diva* you just think, I look at the front cover, kind of flick through it and look at the back cover and think 'Phew, what was that about?'

Amy: It's really young snotty crowd. It's not aimed at us. I like *Spare Rib* and I like a bit of politics, a bit of content. I mean, I do get *Diva* and I do read it. It just depends, I like to see what's going on. See what's happening 'you know' so that I know I'm not missing anything. I get it but, really, it annoys me in terms of the politics. I feel like its so divided politics.

Tanya: The *Gay Times* has got more politics. I hate to say that. There's more politics in *Gay Times*, lesbian or whatever. They just have some really good, . . . a really brilliant article about just trends in the gay world. I thought that's much more kind of current and pacy and something I'd want to read whereas *Diva* just, its just like the London guys.

Cleo: I think that's why most people get it.

Here *Diva*, *Gay Times* and other magazines are conceptualized and critiqued as texts which do the work of creating lesbian and gay identities, the reading of which enables forms of interrogation of relationships to, or indeed the existence of, a perceived community. Two important points about the place of reading in policy contexts emerge from these findings. First, given that one of the 'values of reading' in *Framework for the Future* (DCMS, 2003) is of access to 'shared communities', these forms of media culture might lend themselves far more to the idea of a 'public culture'. If the formation of such a culture is one aim of public policy then a broader conception of what constitutes legitimate or useful reading activities might be appropriate. Second, as the evidence on which policy documents such as the *Framework for the Future* and the National Literacy Trust's *Every Which Way We Can* (2005) are based suggests, a concern with *literacy* may be important in addressing questions of social inclusion/exclusion. However, it may also be that, at the same time, concern with 'the literary' and the perpetuation of various forms of literary value focused on 'book culture' at the expense of other forms of reading activity continue to be implicit in the persistence of hierarchies of value which underpin forms of exclusion. With a view to exploring this possible tension, the next two sections outline some findings regarding taste for books in relation to gender and education.

Part 2: Tastes for Reading

Table 2 gives a simple account of how the tastes for the various genres we identified broke down. Respondents were asked to rank their preferences from one to seven, with one meaning 'I like it a lot' and seven meaning 'I do not like it at all'. The genres identified were designed to reflect a range of tastes and interests, including

Table 2 Likes of Genres (row percent)

	Degrees of liking				Degrees of disliking			Likes	Dislikes
	1 ^a	2	3	4	5	6	7		
Whodunits	20	10	17	13	9	7	20	47	37
Science fiction, fantasy and horror	8	6	7	7	8	10	51	22	69
Romances	12	9	10	11	10	12	33	31	55
Biographies and autobiographies	20	20	16	12	7	6	17	54	30
Modern literature	4	9	11	15	14	12	30	24	56
Religious books	4	4	6	8	9	16	51	14	76
Self-help books	13	10	11	11	9	13	36	27	59

^a1 = 'I like it very much', 7 = 'I do not like it at all'. Likes and dislikes columns are (1 + 2 + 3) and (5 + 6 + 7) respectively.

fiction and non-fiction. The world of literary production and consumption is organized around more nuanced and specialist forms of genre than those outlined below, a point which respondents were occasionally keen to point out to us, particularly within the 'science fiction, fantasy and horror' category. Earlier studies (Bennett, Emmison, & Frow, 1999; Bourdieu, 1984) have included a greater number of more specialist forms and there are genres-within-genres, which are important to readers and to analysts. Other popular genres mentioned in the interviews included true-crime and historical detective fiction. The notion of 'genre' itself is contested and problematic in terms of, for example, its reference to qualities inherent in texts themselves or whether it reflects particular forms of reading practice undertaken by readers (Bennett, 1990). These seven simple genres themselves, though, allow for questions of taste to be operationalized and some clear patterns of taste to emerge.

A striking characteristic of the distribution of tastes outlined here is the tendency for some genres to generate quite strong dislikes, rather than particular enthusiasms. In fact, in each of the genres except 'biographies/autobiographies' the '7' column, representing the classification 'I do not like at all', is the largest percentage. This indicates that disliking genres is a more powerful driver of taste than liking in the literary field. Genre fictions such as 'romances' and 'science fiction, fantasy and horror' offer a particularly stark contrast between the relatively small numbers of specialist enthusiasts, and the larger numbers who strongly dislike these forms.

Only 'whodunits' and 'biographies/autobiographies' are more liked than disliked, and for these two genres the pattern is more evenly spread across the seven points of the scale, indicating that these genres generate the least strong negative feelings, i.e. they are generally liked, but not particularly strongly, by around half our sample. In fact, 'biographies/autobiographies' is the single most popular genre across the sample, followed by 'whodunits' and 'romances'. 'Religious books' are the least liked, followed by 'modern fiction'. 'Religious books' are also the most disliked, followed by 'science fiction, fantasy and horror' and 'romances'. The case of 'modern literature', the most clearly high-culture genre, is interesting. It is rarely

strongly liked, scoring the equal lowest score of '1', but it also gets the lowest percentages but one in the 7 category. One interpretation of this maybe a lack of clarity as to what constitutes modern literature (which emerges from some talk in the interviews). There may be ambivalence about it through the negative connotations of 'modern' and a recognition of its value through the positive connotations of 'literature', leading respondents to err on the side of caution in classifying themselves in relation to it.

The effect of gender on the distribution of likes and dislikes reveals the particularity of romance fiction, and the persistence of a gendered literary field such as that revealed by Bennett *et al.* (1999). In the household interviews, women and men tended to offer different explanations for their reading practices, with men in particular tending to explain their reading in terms of practical, useful knowledge, with technical/trade journals or books relating to hobbies being chosen ahead of reading for pleasure. The concentration within these genres on forms of fiction might skew these findings, then, but more women than men appear to like more literary forms.

Table 3 shows the preferences of men and women, together with the ratio of women's likes/dislikes to men's. In each case more women than men like the various genres, with the exception of 'science fiction, fantasy and horror'. This genre is around twice as popular with men as with women, for whom it is the least liked genre. The most dramatic difference is in the taste for 'romances', the least liked amongst men but the second most popular amongst the women in our sample—only eight per cent of men in the sample claimed to like romance fiction, though 50 per cent of women expressed a preference for this genre. Women made up 88 per cent of those who liked this genre. The picture is complicated by the fact that, at the same time, a considerable number of women, 34 per cent, also disliked romance fiction.

Reading for pleasure, regardless of genre, seems to be particularly articulated by respondents in terms of claiming personal space and time—a point that echoes previous research into women's reading in particular (Fowler, 1991; Radway, 1984). The notion of 'escapism', whilst often a pejorative dismissal of cultural products compared to either disinterested aesthetic appreciation or notions of personal development, is central here and we find strong echoes of this in the ways women, and men, talk about their preferred genres. A woman reader of both science fiction and

Table 3 Gender Split amongst Those Who Like/Dislike Each Genre

	Likes			Dislikes		
	Male	Female	Ratio F/M	Male	Female	Ratio F/M
Whodunits	45	55	1.22	43	57	1.33
Science fiction, fantasy and horror	64	36	0.56	39	61	1.56
Romances	12	88	7.33	66	34	0.52
Biographies and autobiographies	44	56	1.27	46	54	1.17
Modern literature	40	60	1.5	47	53	1.13
Religious books	39	61	1.56	47	53	1.13
Self-help books	40	60	1.5	49	51	1.04

romances, a shop worker from Northern Ireland, describes the practical benefit of the literal reclamation of time and space afforded by reading when she explains:

Sometimes when the kids come in I can't concentrate so I get up and go into the kitchen and close the door on them (laughs) and they keep shouting, "Is my dinner ready?" "Yes, it's coming in a minute" and I'm still sitting in the book thinking, 'Go away'!

Science fiction, the only genre clearly skewed towards men, might offer similar opportunities. A male reader, a warehouse manager from South London, described the types of escape enabled by his reclamation of time at work through reading. When asked why he chose science fiction, fantasy and horror (with J.R.R. Tolkien and Terry Brooks being his favourite authors), he explained that he

Just always used them as a mental release, or just to take my mind off things or get my mind into it or my mind off other things. The job I used to do was very boring, most of the time so you're normally just sitting there, keeping an eye on an empty car park virtually.

In both of these examples the choice of a popular form of genre fiction is explained through the perception that reading books removes oneself from everyday experience. The similarity of these accounts is telling and might indicate that, whilst gender is clearly an important factor in determining how a need for free space and time is manifested, some lifestyles, occupations and social positions might generate this need more than others.

Strong dislikes were also evident for genre fiction. For men, explanations for this dislike were based, in the qualitative interviews at least, on the perception that romance fiction was not meant for them and not addressed to their concerns. Some women rejected romances on stylistic grounds, based upon the presumed simplicity of plots and limitations of storylines. Peggy, a member of a focus group with working-class pensioners, preferred the more apparently challenging work of D.H. Lawrence to the Mills and Boon books preferred by her co-respondents, as 'something you could get your teeth into'. Others rejected romances on the grounds of the vision of femininity they offered. A graduate and trained language teacher from Yorkshire described her perception of such books: 'I think they make out women have no intellectual capacity whatsoever and they sit all day just dreaming of Prince Charming. I find them an insult.'

Table 4 shows the spread of tastes as illustrated by logistic regressions that indicate the relative probability of pre-disposition to a particular genre, compared to a reference group. A score of over 1 indicates the group is more pre-disposed to the genre; a score of less than one indicates they are less pre-disposed. The most statistically significant of these odds ratios are shown in bold. Again, this method illustrates how the literary field and taste for books are patterned by gender. Women are more likely than men to like five of the seven genres, with science fiction, fantasy and horror and romances being the most polarized. In the case of the latter, women are almost 15 times more likely to like romance fiction than are men. The particular

Table 4 Logistic Regression of Tastes for Genres^a

	Whod- units	Sci-fi	Romances	Biography/ auto biography	Modern literature	Self- help	Religious
Female	1.04	0.295	14.968	0.992	1.472	1.3	1.446
Ethnicity	0.856	0.603	3.73	0.415	1.12	2.282	11.207
O-level	0.974	1.568	0.858	1.844	1.090	1.345	0.793
A-level	1.09	1.127	0.608	2.474	2.289	1.263	1.032
Degree	1.195	1.950	0.597	2.79	4.591	1.715	1.249
Large employers	1.117	1.080	0.533	0.509	3.214	0.261	1.084
Higher professionals	1.019	0.715	0.332	2.169	1.829	0.026	1.198
Lower professionnals/ higher technicians	1.002	0.742	0.691	2.016	1.240	0.105	0.838
Lower managerial	1.400	1.060	0.763	1.314	1.389	0.954	0.531
Higher supervisory	0.933	0.447	0.919	2.64	2.032	0.524	0.733
Intermediate occupations	0.870	0.661	0.908	2.018	1.464	0.796	0.837
Small employers/ own account workers	0.919	0.728	1.061	0.942	1.231	0.896	0.45
Lower supervisory	0.985	1.101	0.658	1.043	0.880	0.428	1.217
Lower technical	1.218	0.708	0.958	1.699	0.594	0.430	0.952
Routine occupations	0.816	0.666	0.578	0.733	0.733	0.053	0.674
Never worked	0.683	1.910	0.724	1.132	1.051	0.164	1.065

^aReference categories: ethnicity—‘white English’; education—‘no educational qualifications’; occupational class—‘semi-routine occupations’.

location of romance as a genre is illustrated by looking at the figures for educational level. Here all regressions are less than one, with degree level being particularly significant as an indicator that readers with formal educational qualifications are less inclined to this genre. For holders of degrees in particular, ‘romance fiction’ is the only genre which they are less likely to read than are people with no educational qualifications.

Modern literature is also interestingly located, with education again being a key component of a disposition towards this genre. Having any educational qualification again pre-disposes towards liking this genre, though having a degree seems to be a particular driver of this kind of preference. University education, this indicates, trains one to appreciate higher forms of reading. Very few people who were interviewed expressed a particular enthusiasm for this form. Those that did tended to be relatively highly educated and within professional groups. The regressions for higher and lower managerial and higher professional occupational classes bear this out. Higher professionals are around twice as likely as those in semi-routine occupations to like modern literature and biographies/autobiographies. Focus group discussions amongst young professionals, black middle classes, lesbians and

gays (who were largely recruited from within professional circles) and cultural professionals were the most *au fait* with contemporary literary trends and made reference to recent prominent or prize-winning titles, such as those gaining the Booker Prize or Orange Prize. Again this suggests the particular location of an interest in the literary in professional, metropolitan and relatively privileged circles.

The regressions relating to 'ethnicity' assess the relative similarity of tastes of those within the various non-white minority ethnic groups in the UK and those in the 'white English' category. These indicate a strong predisposition towards religious books within the minority ethnic groups, a significant preference for romance fiction and disinclinations towards whodunits, science fiction, fantasy and horror, and particularly biographies and autobiographies. The relatively small numbers of members of these groups within the main sample might mean that these figures are less reliable. The spread of preferences within the ethnic minority boost sample itself, as shown below, allows some significant patterns to emerge.

Religious books emerge here as the most popular genre within the minority ethnic boost sample, as shown in Table 5. This is in stark contrast to their position as the least popular genre within the sample based upon the population as a whole, shown in Table 2. Otherwise, there is a similar spread of tastes to those of the whole population sample within the ethnic minority groups shown here, with strong dislikes being the most common choice. Scores of '7' are most common for every genre except religious books, with 30 per cent or more of respondents in these groups rating 'self-help', 'biographies and autobiographies', 'modern literature' and 'science fiction, fantasy and horror' in this way. These influences of gender, ethnicity and education on taste can be drawn out further by a consideration of questions of knowledge and participation in the literary field.

Table 5 Likes of Genres amongst the Minority Ethnic Sample (row percent)

	Degrees of liking				Degrees of disliking			Likes	Dislikes
	1 ^a	2	3	4	5	6	7		
Whodunits	16	7	15	12	6	2	25	38	33
Science fiction, fantasy and horror	11	10	12	9	7	10	32	33	49
Romances	15	8	9	9	10	15	26	32	51
Biographies and autobiographies	16	12	11	6	9	10	30	39	49
Modern literature	4	8	9	16	11	14	31	21	56
Religious books	28	13	12	9	7	9	19	53	35
Self-help books	11	12	15	9	6	8	34	38	48

^a1 = 'I like it very much', 7 = 'I do not like it at all'. Likes and dislikes columns are (1 + 2 + 3) and (5 + 6 + 7) respectively.

Part 3: Patterns of Participation

The ways in which the literary field is patterned are also demonstrated by a series of questions that sought to 'test' respondents' knowledge of selected texts, chosen

somewhat arbitrarily but with an attempt to connect with different popular and literary trajectories. Three were contemporary best-sellers: *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* by J.K. Rowling; *The Firm* by John Grisham; and Catherine Cookson's *The Solace of Sin*. Two were 'classic novels', one British (*Pride and Prejudice* by Jane Austen), and one designed to tap into European literary canons (*Madame Bovary* by Gustave Flaubert). The final book was *I Know Why the Caged Birds Sing* by Maya Angelou, chosen to tap into global, cosmopolitan and diasporic trajectories. The reported frequency of reading and knowledge of the texts within the main sample are outlined in Table 6.

The least recognized and read are, predictably perhaps, *Madame Bovary* by Gustave Flaubert and *I Know Why the Caged Birds Sing* by Maya Angelou. The most read book, by some distance, is Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice*. This had been read by 38 per cent of the sample as a whole, and by 50 per cent of the women in the sample. The popularity and recognition of this text (only seven per cent of the sample had not heard of it) might reflect both its position in educational curricula and the circulation of the text through television and cinematic adaptations. The survey period coincided with 'The Big Read' initiative, which gave *Pride and Prejudice* considerable prominence. 'The Big Read' was a BBC internet and telephone poll run to discover the nation's 100 most popular books. This was followed by a series of television programmes in which 'book champions' argued the case for each of the top 21 titles, resulting in a second vote to determine the nation's favourite. *Pride and Prejudice*, championed by the writer and actress Meera Syal, eventually came second to J.R.R. Tolkien's *Lord of the Rings* trilogy.

The popularity of a 'classic' novel such as *Pride and Prejudice* is particularly interesting in considering notions of 'high' and 'low' in the literary field, given that significantly more people had read this than the texts chosen to represent popular taste. The relatively low recognition of the Cookson novel is particularly revealing in this regard. Catherine Cookson has been a consistently popular author in the UK for a significant period of time, being until recently the most borrowed author from UK libraries.² *The Solace of Sin* was the most borrowed title from UK libraries in 1999, but only 8 per cent of respondents had read this book. Such relatively low levels of participation across the

Table 6 Frequency of Participation in Six Identified Works (row percent)

Title	Have read	Thinking of reading	Have heard of but not likely to read	Have not heard of the book
<i>Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets</i>	21	14	61	4
<i>Pride and Prejudice</i>	38	9	46	7
<i>The Solace of Sin</i>	8	7	37	48
<i>I Know Why the Caged Birds Sing</i>	4	4	12	80
<i>The Firm</i>	17	12	36	35
<i>Madam Bovary</i>	7	3	30	60

sample as a whole might indicate the existence of library use as a distinct sub-field of the broader literary field, with its own patterns and trends. By contrast, the most recognized book by far was *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets*. This is interesting, given the relatively short space of time the Harry Potter series of books have had to lodge in the collective consciousness, but might be as much an indication of the successes of the film adaptations and the extensive promotional work of the cultural industries surrounding these texts. As one member of a focus group of middle-class pensioners described it: 'I read a *Harry Potter* because I thought I should'.³

Tables 7, 8 and 9 demonstrate some interesting patterns of participation in the literary field according to gender, education and ethnicity. Tables 7 and 8 describe the make-up of the readership of the various texts according to gender and educational qualifications. There is a distinct gender bias demonstrated here, with women making up the majority of readers of each of the titles. Almost three-quarters of the readers of the classic novels, *Pride and Prejudice* and *Madame Bovary*, as well as the literary autobiography from Maya Angelou, were women. Moreover, two-thirds of readers of *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* were women and only 8 per cent of readers of Catherine Cookson's *The Solace of Sin* were men. If these titles represent a cross-section of contemporary literary culture, this strongly suggests that participation in the literary field is a feminized activity, across hierarchies of value.

The spread of educational qualifications across the readership of these titles is similarly revealing. For every title except *The Solace of Sin*, those with degrees make up the largest proportion of the readership. Whilst over 60 per cent of readers of *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets*, *Pride and Prejudice* and *The Firm* do not have a degree, around 50 per cent of the readers of both *I Know Why the Caged Birds Sing* and *Madame Bovary* do. If these last two titles are representative of 'high culture' in a clearer way than *Pride and Prejudice* (having not been 'massified' by cinematic or TV adaptations), then this suggests the enduring existence of a hierarchy for tastes for the literary within the well educated. Some 'popular' forms of reading, represented by *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets*, *The Firm* and *Pride and Prejudice*, also recruit above-average levels of interest from graduates. The case of *The Solace of Sin* bucks this trend, with 41 per cent of its readership having no educational qualifications and with only 11 per cent (by far the lowest percentage amongst these titles) of graduate readership. Again, this points to enduring hierarchies of value within the literary field, complicated by gender.

Table 7 Gender of the Readership of the Six Titles (percentage)

Gender	Harry Potter	Pride & Prejudice	The Solace of Sin	The Firm	I Know Why the Caged Birds Sing	Madame Bovary
Male	33	27	8	45	23	30
Female	67	74	92	55	77	70
Numbers	330	594	118	268	62	106

Table 8 Educational Qualifications of the Readership of the Six Titles (percentage)

Education	Harry Potter	Pride & Prejudice	The Solace of Sin	The Firm	I Know Why the Caged Birds Sing	Madame Bovary
No qualifications	10	21	41	12	6	8
GCSE	23	20	26	18	10	16
A-level/equivalent	30	24	21	30	32	26
Degree +	36	34	11	38	50	46
Numbers	330	594	118	268	62	106

Finally, a consideration of the influence of ethnicity again suggests a specific social location for book culture. For ease of analysis, white English is compared with the respondents within the minority ethnic boost sample drawn from Afro-Caribbean, Indian and Pakistani communities. Of course, differences within and between these communities, as well as with other white communities within the UK, may well be significant. This simple measure begins, though, to point to the ways in which patterns of participation in the literary field are affected by ethnicity. The most read book in both samples was *Pride and Prejudice*, and there is an interesting similarity between the proportions of readers of the most apparently literary (*Madame Bovary*) and the least (*The Solace of Sin*). We can see that, for every title except the Maya Angelou, a significantly greater percentage of the white English members of the main sample than of the 'ethnic boost' sample have read each title. The arbitrariness of the selection of these titles means that the significance of this can be overstated, but if, as seems to emerge by examination of the other variables on offer here, there is a literary culture, then it is one which the majority of people do not connect with and, more specifically, one which members of ethnic minorities tend to be less engaged by.

Table 9 Comparison of the Frequency of Readership of the Six Titles between White English and Minority Ethnic Sample (percentage)

Ethnicity	Harry Potter	Pride & Prejudice	The Solace of Sin	The Firm	I Know Why the Caged Birds Sing	Madame Bovary	Numbers
White English	23	40	7	18	4	7	1116
Afro-Caribbean/ Indian and Pakistani	15	26	3	12	6	2	265

Conclusions

This article has used the findings of the *Cultural Capital and Social Exclusion* survey and its accompanying qualitative data to suggest some ways in which the literary

field, as defined by taste and participation in book culture, is patterned. Whilst participation in book culture is largely concentrated into a significant minority, reading practices in themselves are more diverse when magazine and newspaper reading is taken into account. This may be significant, given the ways in which reading or its lack is constituted as a policy problem, particularly in terms of links between questions of literacy and debates framed around basic skills and social inclusion/exclusion or claims that are made for reading in terms of its presumed ability to 'give people access to shared conversations and communities' (DCMS, 2003, p. 24). Critical engagement with reading matter was, in the qualitative component of our study, more likely to emerge in talk about media reading cultures than about book preferences.

In this light it is less clear how and why, if people do read, tastes in reading can be constituted as a problem without implicit reproduction of hierarchies of value in cultural activity. This article has outlined the importance of occupational class to questions of ownership of books and participation in book culture, suggesting that, despite the changes identified to other cultural fields in terms of broader participation and omnivorousness, tastes for reading are still concentrated within the better educated and within groups of relative socio-economic privilege. These groups are also more likely to prefer and engage in forms of the literary across hierarchies, with the exception of popular romance novels. Such groups are also more likely to prefer modern literature and, drawing on the focus group and interview material, be more au fait with current literary trends.

The study also finds particular polarization of the literary field according to gender. Gender appears to be an important determinant of engagement with the literary field, as well as a major influence in genre preferences. Women seem to participate more than men in reading activities across hierarchies of value. Some genres ('whodunits', 'biographies/autobiographies') are relatively gender neutral, whilst others ('science fiction, fantasy and horror' and 'romances') are more preferred by one gender than another. What is of equal interest is that the reasons given for these preferences suggest that it is not the gendered subject matter of such texts *per se* so much as their ability to be used by readers in particular ways that makes them attractive to both men and women. The physical and temporal reclamation of spaces for the self, articulated through 'escape', is important here. Given that the need for these forms of escape is articulated by men and women about different genres, it is perhaps not only the gender of the readers or the apparently 'gendered' nature of the subject matter of these works that is significant, but also other elements of their social location, including educational experience and occupational class.

Finally, measurements of participation in literary cultures organized around questions relating to specific texts have further suggested the continued existence of sharp divisions in taste. These divisions are again informed by gender, with women more likely than men to engage in contemporary literary culture, across genres and across hierarchies of the literary. This is complicated somewhat with the case of *Pride and Prejudice*, a 'literary' novel that is both consecrated and popular, across class, education and gender lines. Such a finding might point to the existence of a national

literary canon. The relative weighting of its popularity amongst an identified ethnic sample might suggest, though, that national literary cultures might not be attractive or accessible to all. If, in particular, *Pride and Prejudice* and *Harry Potter* are examples of literary culture which make claims to represent or inform forms of national identity, then they are not forms to which everyone relates in equal measure.

Notes

- [1] The CCSE survey was administered to adults only. There were questions asked about parental involvement in reading activities, which are not reported here. Interestingly several parents interviewed in the qualitative phase, whilst not readers themselves, emphasized the importance of reading for children, with 'reading' being interpreted as almost synonymous with education in general.
- [2] After 17 successive years as the most borrowed author, Cookson was recently usurped by the children's writer Jacqueline Wilson (Public Lending Right Registry, 2004).
- [3] There is a clear difference between participation and preference and, just because one has read something, it does not follow that one likes it. Our measures of participation do not include an option for critical appraisal of the texts, though it is interesting to note that, in the qualitative part of the study, there were relatively few examples of people who proclaimed dislikes of books that they had read. Dislikes were far more forthcoming about magazines and newspapers.

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